

« BEFORE

History showed how committed guerrilla fighters could beat a well-trained professional army.

PAST SUCCESS

The Viet Minh had fought a **guerrilla war** against the French in Vietnam during the **First Indochina War**, progressing from rural ambushes and raids to ambitious confrontations using sophisticated weapons. Their success had led to the **creation of communist North Vietnam**.

THE TIME IS RIGHT

As President Diem hunted down insurgents in South Vietnam, the Central Committee in the North weighed its options. Should North Vietnam adhere to the “peaceful political action,” favored by Ho Chi Minh in 1954, after the First Indochina War, or was it ready to renew armed struggle in the South?



BAS-RELIEF OF HO CHI MINH WITH VICTORIOUS VIET MINH IN QUANG TRI

At the end of the 1950s, South Vietnam appeared to be reasonably prosperous and stable—thanks to more than \$200 million worth of military and economic assistance from the US each year. By 1960, such aid made up as much as 70 percent of the country’s total budget, and Saigon was booming. The South Vietnamese capital, however, was not typical. Little, if anything, was being done to improve conditions in the villages where 90 percent of the population lived.

This meant that insurgency found a ready audience. The peasants, one guerrilla said after his capture, were “like a mass of straw ready to be ignited.” Even anticommunists living in South Vietnam agitated for change.

Use of force

As America poured resources into propping up the Diem regime in South Vietnam, Le Duan, a former activist in South Vietnam, who had taken refuge in the North, pressed fellow members of North Vietnam’s politburo to provide greater support for the insurgents in the South. As a result, in January 1959, the committee sanctioned the use of force in South Vietnam. While not wishing to provoke their opponents, especially the Americans, by an outright invasion, it sought to build an effective guerrilla army in the South and supply it with weapons. It established Group 559 to organize supply lines.